# "Don't let them dig our future away — mountains bleed so rivers die!"

*Authored by Jacey Lorenz Gulmatico*

This slogan speaks directly to open-pit and large-scale mining operations that carve through mountainsides across Mindanao, including areas near Davao's watersheds. When mining companies excavate mountains, the exposed rock and soil release acid mine drainage and heavy metals that flow downstream and contaminate river systems. The phrase "mountains bleed" captures how mining wounds the land visually and chemically: the reddish-brown slurry that pours from mining sites into rivers is, quite literally, the mountain bleeding out. "Rivers die" is not poetic exaggeration. Fish dying, turbid water, and the disappearance of potable sources have been documented in communities near mining sites in Compostela Valley, South Cotabato, and other parts of Mindanao. The opening warning "don't let them dig our future away" frames mining not as a static act but as a theft of what is still to come.

Behind the literal images lies a harder truth about power and sacrifice. Mountains in Philippine indigenous culture, including among the Lumad communities of Mindanao, are not simply geological features, they are ancestral domains, sources of identity, and living ecosystems that sustain lowland communities downstream. When a mountain is blasted open for nickel or gold, the destruction is not only environmental but cultural. "Our future" in the slogan is deliberately plural: it belongs to farmers who depend on clean irrigation water, to fisherfolk in Davao Gulf whose catch is affected by sedimentation, to mothers who cannot give their children safe drinking water, and to future generations who will inherit either a living watershed or a scarred, toxic landscape. The slogan also quietly challenges the economic argument that mining brings development by asking what kind of future is built on poisoned rivers and collapsed ecosystems. No ore in the ground is worth more than water.

Davao is both blessed and besieged by its geography. The mountain ranges that cradle the region feed the rivers like the Davao River, Tagum, Hijo that give life to agriculture, communities, and the Gulf. Large-scale mining concessions have been applied for and contested across these same ranges for decades. Choosing this topic is not abstract for someone living here, it is about the water that comes out of the tap, the fish in the market, and whether the children of Mindanao will grow up beside living rivers or open pits. The call to action in this slogan is urgent: pay attention before the damage is irreversible. Once a river system is contaminated with heavy metals, restoration takes generations. We do not have that kind of time to waste.

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BEFORE MINING
AFTER MINING
PROTECT MINDANAO'S WATERSHEDS
#NoToDestructiveMining #DavaoWatershed